

FiCEP Curriculum Redesign

Training needs analysis

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WHAT THIS IS

Chartway runs a ten-week program that prepares employees for America's Credit Unions' financial counseling certification exam, using ACU's Financial Counseling Examination Preparation (FiCEP) materials. After ACU released the sixth edition of those materials, first-attempt pass rates fell. This needs analysis finds out why and recommends what to change.

I conducted the interviews and survey, analyzed the results and wrote the report, working with the Financial Wellness manager as the program's subject matter expert.

FINDINGS AT A GLANCE

5

semi-structured interviews

21

survey responses from recent participants

23

mentions of needing more study time, the top barrier

- Even with supportive managers, people studied on their own time; one respondent reported 10 to 12 hours of unpaid study.
- Learners found the study guide helpful (17 mentions), wanted content tied to Chartway's own products and services (16), and said the practice exam didn't match the real one (12).

WHAT I RECOMMENDED

- At least 2 hours a week of protected study time, backed by a leaders' kickoff meeting, a leaders' guide and weekly updates
- A welcome meeting that sets expectations, and check-ins rebuilt as mandatory FiCEP Success Sessions
- A curriculum tied to Chartway's products, services and practices
- Realistic practice exams, flash cards, role plays and Rise activities
- Surveys for learners and managers mid-program and at the end

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Outcome. Chartway implemented the redesigned program and reported improved exam results.

Training Launch Needs Analysis

FiCEP Curriculum Redesign

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Project Details

Project Resources

Role	Name
Instructional Designer	Jordan Charles
Project Department	Financial Wellness
Manager	Name withheld for privacy

Project Description and Notes

America's Credit Unions (ACU) recently released the sixth edition of their Financial Counseling Examination Preparation (FiCEP) materials, resulting in a decline in examination pass rates for Organization employees throughout 2024. Prior to the update, the April 2023 cohort (used as a baseline) set the benchmark first-attempt pass rate; combined 2024 data show a significant decline from that baseline. Exact pass rates and cohort sizes are withheld to protect employee privacy.

The existing preparation program maintains a ten-week instructional format including assigned readings from the updated materials, scheduled webinars, structured learner support through welcome and three check-in sessions, optional test preparation meetings, study guides, and access to ACU's complete resource library. The progressive nature of the performance decline throughout 2024 suggests systematic instructional challenges with the updated sixth edition rather than a temporary adjustment period, indicating the need for targeted intervention to restore examination success rates to acceptable levels.

Problem to Be Solved with New Product/Service/Process:

Problem Statement

Organization's current FiCEP program faces a critical performance challenge that impedes both individual team member development and organizational training effectiveness. Following the implementation of the sixth edition materials, examination pass rates have shown a statistically significant decline (exact figures are withheld to protect employee privacy). This decline has been persistent, with monthly cohorts underperforming compared to historical standards, indicating systematic instructional inadequacies rather than temporary adjustment difficulties.

This performance gap has implications for multiple stakeholders within Organization. Individual team members face extended timelines to certification, increased examination costs from retesting requirements, and potential career advancement delays. At the company level: Organization has a diminished return on professional development investments, as well as challenges in maintaining adequate numbers of certified financial counselors to serve member's needs. At the member level, the declining pass rates may compromise the overall quality and consistency of financial counseling certification available to Organization members, potentially affecting member satisfaction outcomes. The magnitude and persistence of this performance decline suggests immediate programmatic intervention to restore program effectiveness and ensure sustainable professional development pathways for Organization team members.

Training Goals:

The redesigned FiCEP Program aims to restore examination pass rates to baseline performance levels or higher while enhancing overall learner engagement and knowledge retention. Team members will demonstrate mastery of financial counseling principles, regulatory requirements, and practical application skills necessary to successfully pass ACU's financial counseling certification examination on their first attempt. The training will develop critical thinking capabilities for real-world financial counseling scenarios, improve confidence in applying theoretical knowledge to practice situations. Additionally, the program seeks to reduce time-to-competency for Organization team members entering financial counseling roles and increase overall satisfaction with the learning experience.

Content Source:

- The primary subject matter expert will be Organization's Financial Wellness manager.
- The sixth edition of ACU's FiCEP materials (i.e., webinars, book, study guide).

Important Dates:

- May 30th Finish reading the FiCEP book
- June 4th Finish interviews
- June 20th Finish Needs analysis

Data Methods

The data collection strategy employed a qualitative approach to comprehensively assess learner experiences and identify performance barriers. Semi-structured interviews were conducted with five program participants using a standardized question framework to gather in-depth insights regarding learning experiences, material challenges, instructional delivery effectiveness, and examination preparation factors. Additionally, a survey was distributed to recent program participants to collect qualitative data that may influence outcomes. This combined approach provides understanding to suggest curriculum redesign recommendations that are grounded in comprehensive empirical evidence across diverse Organization team member contexts.

Data Collected

- Data collection for this needs analysis employed a mixed-methods approach combining semi-structured interviews and a survey distribution to recent program participants. The interview phase yielded in-depth qualitative insights from five Organization team members who participated in the FiCEP program. These interviews captured perspectives on learning experiences, instructional effectiveness, organizational support factors, and examination preparation challenges
- The survey phase, designed to validate and expand upon interview findings through Qualitative survey data collection. This survey targets a broader participant population to gather statistical insights regarding learner satisfaction, content comprehension patterns, and resource utilization preferences. 21 responses were recorded.

Data Analysis/Themes Analysis

- Combined analysis of interview and survey data reveals consistent patterns that inform curriculum redesign priorities. The most critical finding addresses organizational support structures, with both data sources highlighting time allocation challenges as a primary barrier to program success. While half of survey respondents reported positive management support, they along with interview data revealed that even supportive management often struggled to provide adequate protected study time due to operational demands. Multiple participants across both data collection methods indicated studying during personal time rather than allocated work hours, with one survey respondent specifically noting ten to twelve hours of unpaid personal study time required for examination success.
- Time assessment preparation and content customization emerged as significant areas. Interview analysis identified practice examination inadequacy as the second most frequent issue, with participants noting discrepancies between practice materials and actual examination requirements, particularly regarding question complexity and formatting techniques. Survey data corroborated this finding while also revealing strong consensus regarding content customization preferences, with applicable respondents viewing Organization specific examples as valuable or highly valuable. Participants specifically requested integration of familiar organizational products, services, and scenarios to enhance practical application and knowledge retention.

Table 1: Interview mentions for each topic

Rank	Mentions	Count
1	Management Needs to Set Apart More Time	23
2	Study Guide was Helpful	17
3	Personalized per the organization Content	16
4	I had Management Support	15
5	Need Better Practice Exam	12
6	Check in was Helpful	10
7	Check in Frequency was Good	9
8	Webinars were NOT Helpful	6
9	More Check ins	5

Theme Analysis

- Three primary themes emerged from the combined dataset to guide curriculum redesign efforts. First, organizational structural barriers consistently overshadowed instructional content issues, with time allocation challenges appearing as the most frequently cited obstacle across both data collection methods. Second, assessment alignment gaps created significant learner frustration and potentially contributed to declining pass rates, as participants consistently reported that practice materials inadequately prepared them for actual examination requirements. Third, learner preference diversity requires flexible instructional approaches, with participants demonstrating varied needs for collaboration frequency, content delivery methods, and support structures while maintaining consistent demand for practical, context-specific learning applications that connect theoretical knowledge to workplace responsibilities.

Audience Analysis

Audience	Roles	How FiCEP Knowledge will be used
Retail Leaders	Branch Managers	• Coach RMs and RSs and coach members
	MSC Managers	• Coach their teams and members
Retail TMs	Relationship Specialist	• Coach members
	Relationship Managers	• Coach Members
	FSR I	• Coach Members or refer to services
	FSR II	• Coach Members or refer to services
	FSS	• Coach Members or refer to services
	Interactive Tellers	• Refer to services
Member Experience (MX) Team	Interactive Specialist	• Coach Members or refer to services
	Manager Member Experience	• Have knowledge of coaching services
	Member Liaison Specialist	
Internal Solutions Center (ISC)	Synapsys Administrator	
	ISS I	• Have knowledge of coaching services and refer as necessary
	ISS II	
Survivor Support	All	• Have knowledge of coaching services and refer as necessary
Fraud	All	• Have knowledge of coaching services and refer as necessary
Cards	All	• Have knowledge of coaching services and refer as necessary
Consumer Lending	All	• Have knowledge of coaching services and refer as necessary
Indirect Lending	All	• Have knowledge of coaching services and refer as necessary
Real Estate	All	• Have knowledge of coaching services and refer as necessary
Business	All	• Have knowledge of coaching services and refer as necessary
Non-Member Facing Departments	Application Technology (AT)	• Have knowledge of coaching services and refer as necessary

Information Technology (IT)	• Have knowledge of coaching services and refer as necessary
Data Analytics/Data Engineering (DA/DE)	• Have knowledge of coaching services and refer as necessary
Project Management Office (PMO)	• Have knowledge of coaching services and refer as necessary
L&D	• Have knowledge of coaching services and refer as necessary provide information on FW initiatives during onboarding, support team members as necessary • The Financial Wellness Manager will run the program
Marketing	• Have knowledge of coaching services and prepare marketing strategies for services
HR/Talent	• Have knowledge of coaching services and refer as necessary prospective new hires of Organization FW initiatives • Understanding of the requirements for Career Progression

Training Suggestions

Proposed Learning Strategies and Methods

- Strategies:
 - The program should implement organizational support frameworks that ensure protected learning time, competency-based pacing that accommodates individual learning needs, and contextual learning approaches that connect theoretical knowledge to practical workplace applications. Additionally, assessment alignment strategies should ensure practice materials accurately reflect certification examination standards.
- Methods:
 - Recommended delivery methods include (optional if they want it) protected study time blocks built into work schedules, enhanced practice examination systems with varied question types and difficulty levels (e.g., double negatives, or obvious questions), and for those who have been here a while: Organization specific case studies and scenarios integrated throughout content delivery, and flexible check-in formats for those that want more, or less frequent check-ins that accommodate different learning preferences. Lastly, office hours for one-on-one support options for learners that could benefit from additional assistance.

Training Materials Proposal

The following are my proposed interventions and approaches towards the FiCEP training

a. Leadership Support - Establish Expectations with Leaders

- Having a leadership meeting with leaders to set up expectations. Managers should expect to schedule at least 2 hours each week per team member for the program. During these 2 hours, learners will either use the time to study materials, attend classes, or schedule time with the Financial Wellness manager (available via her booking page).
- Leaders teams chat, having a 2-3 sentence quick updates that is sent to leaders to tell them what is going on with their team members that week.
- Leaders Guide – much like the one for interns having a guide of what is talked about and topics to talk about with team members
 - Picture from intern program as an example (**removed for confidentiality**)

- Leader surveys –We will send a survey to managers at the mid and ending of the program.
These surveys will allow us to have manager feedback on the resources and timing of the program.
- Mid program touch base meeting – a teams meeting to discuss how the cohort is doing and reminders for leaders, in addition to hearing leaders concerns/questions.
- This Leadership Support recommendation and all elements directly address the most frequently cited barrier across both data sources, with 23 mentions of time allocation challenges, with one survey respondent reporting 10-12 hours of unpaid personal study time. Even participants with supportive management struggled to find adequate study time during work hours due to competing operational demands. Some people may need extra time, but at least 2 hours of paid personal study should be expected. Therefore, people will need to know the commitment of time in order to pass.

b. Initial Meeting - Establish Expectations With Learners

- Having a welcome meeting with learners to set expectations, emphasize the time needed, emphasize the curriculum structure, and explain the resources that are available.
- This recommendation directly addresses the first most frequently cited barrier, (time), and ensures learners understand the commitment to the program.

c. Rebranding Check-In to Ficep Success Session {Topic}.

- Currently we have FiCEP check ins that allow team members to ask questions, and we briefly go over the chapter. We want to rebrand this to teach more content from the chapters and related to Organization (more on that below) and how we can serve our members with it, in addition to all of that we want to allow learners to share insights and ask questions.
- Furthermore, these rebranded “FiCEP Success Session {Topic}” will be mandatory, which will ensure management sets aside time to attend, and learners should learn more about the content and thus should pass the exam first try.
- This recommendation directly addresses, the first most frequently cited barrier, (Needing time), and 6th (Check in was helpful) & 9th (More Check ins). Some people said they wanted more check ins, and some said they were just fine.

d. Curriculum that’s Personalized per the organization

- Most team members wanted a Personalized per the organization curriculum that is like the book but also relates the chapter content to Organization products, services, and practices.
- In addition to relating the content to Organization in the facilitated sessions, the curriculum will include:
 - Activities
 - Quizzes – aka knowledge checks
 - (See below for an example of chapter 4).

Chapter 4 Personalized per the organization example:

Chapter 4	America's Credit Unions Approach (FiCEP)	Organization Credit Union Approach
Do not Change Members Values	Help members change their money attitudes, behaviors, and perceptions, not their values. Values are deeply held principles that are relatively stable and represent core ideas about desirable goals formed by experiences.	Here at Organization, we put members first. Because we put members first, we don't try to change their values - we respect what's important to them. Instead, we help them align their financial behaviors with their existing values to achieve their goals.

- This recommendation directly addresses the second most frequent item: Personalized per the organization content. With 16 people requesting this, with one user saying “I love this idea.”

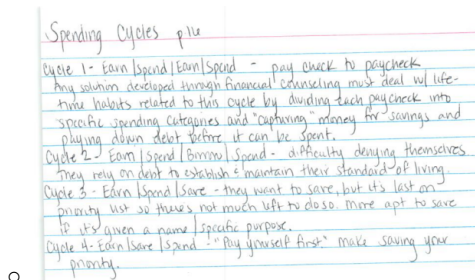
And another said “I think that would be way valuable because that is what me and my manager did. Once she explained in our organization terms it helped a lot.” We have an interest in getting a Personalized per the organization version of the curriculum.

e. Feedback Surveys

- Along with the quizzes we would have a mid-program and end-of-year feedback survey. The questions we would ask would help us to find out how they are doing, so that we can track what is effective for learners and be able to pass that on to future cohorts.
- This is good instructional practice and discovers if changes need to be made, and if learner needs are being met.

f. Additional Tools to Support Team Members

- We could have a variety of practice exams, aiming to build confidence for those that struggle with test anxiety. We would start throughout the course with the Low-Stakes knowledge checks culminating in a practice examination that accurately reflects actual certification test complexity and question formatting, with questions with double negatives, similar answer choices, and reading comprehension challenges that mirror the actual exam structure.
- Branded Flash Cards – we could make flash cards for them to print off or use virtually, we could make something using Anki (GitHub Repository) to be able to make spaced repetitions for users to practice what they do or don’t need.
 - Here is an example of a flash card (without the branding)



- Role play – we could come up with role plays for team members to practice with
- Rise activities – We could make the following kinds of activities inside rise to give users to option to pick and choose how they would like to learn.
 - Matching - Simple matching activity for team members to use to help learn terms and concepts
 - Choose your own adventure experience – Learners get to choose how to respond to member needs and we can use branching to help team members have more in-depth role play
- This recommendation addresses the fifth most frequent issue, “Need Better Practice Exam” with 12 specific mentions. Survey participants noted significant discrepancies between practice materials and actual examination requirements. Participants consistently reported that current practice questions failed to prepare them for the complexity and formatting techniques used in the actual certification exam. Along with that we are building better study tools to help users deepen their knowledge and practically apply what they learn.

Questions

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